

The Market of Mixed-Up Magic

The Floating Isles are islands adrift in a calm sky, in a realm where magic only ever helps: it grows, it heals, it changes one thing into another, and it lets you speak with animals and objects. It never harms. On the home island, the House of the Little Mages sits at the highest point, where young mages learn their first spells, and the city where the families live spreads below. Inside the school grounds lies the Great Garden, the green heart of the whole island. Here nobody loses; you find your way by being clever and kind.



The Market of Mixed-Up Magic

Read aloud, or let an older child read. Pause at the questions and let everyone share their ideas. There are no wrong answers, only new ones to try.

Before you begin

Market day on the home island is the busiest, brightest morning of the week. All along the Market Row the stalls are heaped high: warm loaves cooling on the baker's counter, ripe fruit stacked in glowing pyramids, neat rows of shoes at the cobbler's, and a whole rainbow of toys waiting to be wound up and played with.

Then comes a small flash, a soft pop, and a sound like the whole market drawing a surprised breath. When it clears, everything has jumped to the wrong place. The baker stands blinking at a pair of muddy boots. The cobbler turns a kite over in puzzled hands. Fruit sits where toys should be, toys where bread should be, and not a single stallholder can find a thing that belongs to them.

You are young mages, and a tangle like this is exactly the sort of thing you are learning to mend. You share a quick look and roll up your sleeves. "Let us untangle the market," you say, and the muddle waits for you.

What is your mage name? Which magic feels most like you today: Light, Grow, Change, or Voice?

Stop 1: The Muddled Stalls

You make your way down the row, and everywhere you look an object sits where it does not belong, looking faintly bewildered. A pair of boots blinks up at you from among the loaves, as if to ask how on earth it ended up there.

The Mist Cat pads out of the morning haze and settles at your side, soft and grey and ready to lend a paw.

How will you discover where each thing belongs? Could you simply ask the objects themselves where their home is? Try something, and see what the market tells you.

Once the objects begin to name their proper stalls, you set to work carrying them home, and the easy ones are soon back in their places. But a handful are still hopelessly jumbled, and for those you will need to think a little harder.

Stop 2: The Memory of the Market

To untangle the rest, you must call up a picture of the market as it was before the spell went wrong: which stall held which goods, and exactly where everything stood. That is no small thing, with the whole row shuffled around you.

A Talking Flower, nodding in its pot on the corner, leans close and hums the market back to you in order, stall by stall, like a little song you can lean on.

Can you remember which stall sold the bread, which the fruit, which the shoes, and which the toys? Match each muddled thing back to the stall it came from.

As each thing returns to where it began, more and more of the Market Row settles into happy order again. Only one stubborn knot is left, and it is the trickiest of them all.

Stop 3: The Last Swap

Three stalls remain tangled, and they are tangled in a ring. The baker is holding a pair of boots, the cobbler is holding a kite, and the toymaker is holding a fresh loaf of bread. Every one of them has something that belongs to one of the others, and to set it right you must work

out, carefully, who should pass which thing along to whom.

*Who hands their thing to whom, so that in the end every stall has exactly what it should?
Reason it out together, one pass at a time.*

When the last swap comes untangled and each stall holds its own again, a cheer runs the length of the Market Row. Everything is mended. Yet one question still hangs in the air, unanswered: where did all this muddle begin?

Pip the New Mage

Behind a quiet stall at the far end, you find the answer curled up small and trying very hard to be invisible: a young apprentice mage, no older than you, with a pointed hat sitting crooked over a worried face. Their name is Pip, and today is their very first day of magic.

Pip, you learn, had only wanted to help. They had tried a small Change spell to tidy a stall, and the spell had slipped and spun out across the whole market, swapping everything as it went. Frightened of the muddle they had made, and far too shy to own up, Pip had crept away to hide.

There is no scolding here, and there never was anything to fear. Everyone fumbles a spell now and then, and a first day is exactly when it is most likely to happen.

What do you say to Pip? How can you show them that all is well, that no one is cross, and that nobody mended this market alone, you mended it together?

When you tell Pip, gently and truly, that everything is alright, they uncurl and peep out with the smallest of smiles. Then, steadier now, Pip lifts one careful Change and sets the very last thing right, and the whole Market Row breaks into applause. Pip straightens up and stands a little taller than before.

You did this together. You were clever, and you were kind, and on the Isles that is the only way anyone ever wins.

The Story in Pictures



A row of market stalls with goods swapped around, two young mages asking a pair of boots where they belong amid soft magic sparkles.



Two young mages returning goods to the right stalls, loaves and toys floating back, the Mist Cat beside them helping them remember.



A shy young apprentice mage peeking from behind a stall while two young mages reassure them with kind smiles, the friendly market all around.

My Adventure Sheet

Draw your hero

My name

I am a hero of

My energy stars (colour one in when you spend it)



My magics



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can

What I carry

Notes

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.

Wits and Wonder

Story Pack

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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